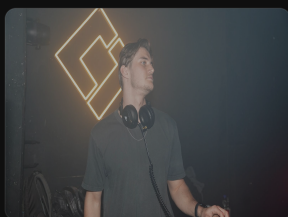




FREE ARTIST GUIDE

The Rise Artist Guide

Your career checklist + key insights from
10 industry professionals on production,
branding, bookings, and more.



Artist Career Checklist

Check off each item as you build your artist career. Be honest.

IDENTITY & VISION

- ☐ Defined your WHY in one sentence
- ☐ Identified your 2-3 brand archetypes
- ☐ Written your artist origin story
- ☐ Created a visual moodboard (20-30 images)
- ☐ Built consistent visual identity across platforms
- ☐ Defined your communication formula

PRODUCTION & SOUND

- ☐ Built a DAW template with groups, utilities & metering
- ☐ Programmed hi-hats by hand with velocity variation
- ☐ Built a kick from scratch using synthesis + layering
- ☐ Tested tracks on multiple systems (low vol, bad speakers, car)
- ☐ Applied the 85% rule: stopped before overthinking
- ☐ Finished at least 5 tracks end-to-end

MIXING & MASTERING

- ☐ Set up reference tracks in every session
- ☐ Applied 20-min mixing rule with breaks
- ☐ Gain staged every channel (-5dB utility, -10dB fader)
- ☐ Built a mastering chain: compressor, shelf, clipper, limiter

MARKETING & SOCIAL MEDIA

- ☐ Archived posts that don't build status
- ☐ Created 3 pinned posts: Hero, Architect, Access
- ☐ Organized Highlights: Start Here, Standard, Validation
- ☐ Written a clear, specific bio (no cliches)
- ☐ Planned 5 cold-entry reels (one micro-problem each)
- ☐ Sending voice memos to new followers

BOOKINGS & NETWORKING

- ☐ Prepared a clean press kit (bio, photos, releases, sets)
- ☐ Written your positioning statement
- ☐ Researched 3 promoters/bookers you respect
- ☐ Answered honestly: would you book yourself?

BUSINESS & RIGHTS

- ☐ Registered with your local PRO (Buma/Stemra, etc.)
- ☐ Created split sheets for all collaborations
- ☐ Reviewed any existing contracts for term & ownership
- ☐ Set up a release schedule (not 'when it feels ready')
- ☐ Scheduled daily studio time on your calendar

Production & Sound

Actionable insights you can implement today. Each one comes from the Rise Manual — tested by working artists and industry professionals.

Build your kick from scratch

Start with a sine wave. Shape the pitch envelope: 90Hz to 50Hz over 50ms, tiny rise to 60Hz. Attack 5-10ms, decay around 500ms. Then layer it with a sample — synth carries sub + mid, sample carries click + attack. This is what professional kicks sound like: composites, not single hits.

Double sidechain your bass

First sidechain: kick-triggered, 150ms release, creates the rhythmic pump. Second sidechain: self-filtered (boost high-mids, then sidechain compressor, 1-2dB). This makes your bass punchy and present. Most producers never use it. Once you hear the difference, you can't unhear it.

The 85% rule

When your arrangement works — groove is tight, structure makes emotional sense — stop. You're at 85%. The last 15% is overthinking territory. Extra layers and effects feel productive but make the track muddy. Finished is a decision. Most tracks die from overthinking.

Program hi-hats by hand

No loops. 16th notes with velocity variation: 70%, 85%, 90% — hand-adjust each hit. Then micro-timing: shift every other hit 5-10ms off grid. Push and pull, like a human drummer fighting the beat. This takes 30 minutes and completely changes how your drums feel.

Use a template that's ready to go

Groups by function (drums, bass, melody, FX). -5dB utility on every track as first insert. Fader starts at -10dB. Reference tracks loaded. Metering visible. When you open a new session, you press play and sound is ready. You're making music, not fiddling with setup.

The 20-minute mixing rule

Your ears adapt after 20 minutes. Mix for 20 minutes, break for 5. Switch monitoring: headphones, speakers, earbuds. A/B against reference tracks every 2 minutes. If you need more than 6dB of EQ, you have a source problem, not a mixing problem.

Low volume reveals the truth

Turn monitors to conversation level. Does the groove still work? If your track only sounds good at club volume, you have a problem. Test on earbuds, laptop speakers, car stereo. Not for perfection — for translation.

Branding & Identity

Your music is the foundation, but identity is what makes people stay. These insights help you build something recognizable and lasting.

Start with WHY — not what you do

"I make music because ____." Not about success. About purpose. When you're clear about your WHY, you make music based on what matters to you. When you're unclear, you chase what you think people want. Clarity resonates. Purpose is magnetic.

Three pillars: Music, Brand, Hype

Music is the foundation — without it, nothing. Brand is how people recognize you — your visual identity, story. Hype is momentum — buzz, playlists, bookings. Most artists overweight one pillar. A great producer invisible on socials. A strong brand with no music. Balance all three.

The molecule principle

Your brand has a nucleus: your core artistic identity in one sentence. Everything orbits that: artwork, collaborations, venues, content, social media. Without a nucleus, you're scattered. With one, every element reinforces the others. One clear identity beats five possibilities.

Identify your archetypes

12 archetypal characters humans recognize: Creator, Explorer, Rebel, Hero, Sage, Magician, Everyman, Caregiver, Ruler, Lover, Jester, Innocent. You're a blend of 2-3. Identify yours and build everything around them. This makes you feel coherent, not random.

21/7 rhythm for sound identity

21 days of composition — no editing, just making. Then 7 days of definition — step back and evaluate. What's actually good? This prevents perfectionism and gives you perspective. After 21 days, you see patterns. You see your actual direction, not what you think it should be.

The communication formula

"I make music for [audience], because they have [emotional need], and I deliver that through [my approach]."
Example: music for young professionals escaping routine, through heavy 808s and hypnotic loops. That's specific. That's a direction. Use it to guide every piece of content.

One platform, executed well

Instagram is where the industry judges you. One conversion engine: reels for strangers (micro-problem in 15s), stories for followers (personality + process), three pinned posts as your 24/7 sales team. Archive anything that doesn't build status. 12 strong posts beat 300 mediocre ones.

Career & Business

The music industry runs on clarity, relationships, and understanding what you own. These insights cover bookings, label strategy, rights, and the mindset that sustains a career.

Would you book yourself?

If you were a programmer tomorrow, would you put yourself on the lineup? If no — fix it. Maybe your profile, your energy in the room, your network, your consistency. Become the artist you would book. A programmer will eventually ask themselves the same question.

A&R decides in 30 seconds

Groove (does it move?), sound palette (is it intentional?), mix balance (does it hold?). If any of these are off in the first 30 seconds, the rest never gets heard. Use a preset synth and it's instantly audible. Custom sounds show investment. Presets show you're still learning.

Trends are 1-2 years old when they chart

The trend you're hearing is old news. Chasing it means you're already behind. Trend hoppers can't build full careers. Artists who own a sound — who develop and evolve it on their own terms — that's sustainable. That's bookable. That's what labels actually want.

Labels sign artists, not tracks

A nice track doesn't equal a strong project. A&Rs want journeys, not moments. Pitch the journey: "Here's my latest release, but also here's where I'm going." Music is the entry point. Identity is what makes people stay. Build both.

Register with your PRO today

Buma/Stemra, ASCAP, PRS — whatever your territory. It's free. Every time your music is played publicly, performance royalties are generated. If you're not registered, you're leaving money on the table. One-time work, lifetime income.

Split sheets before finishing any collab

Who wrote what, who produced what, what's the ownership split. Get signatures. Store it safely. This prevents disasters when money appears and nobody remembers who owns what. "We'll figure it out later" is how friendships end.

Term length matters more than advances

A small advance with non-exclusive rights and a short term (1-3 years) beats a larger advance with exclusive rights for 7 years. Your music library is an asset that appreciates. Every track generates potential income for decades. Before signing: read term, exclusivity, ownership.



THE MINDSET THAT SUSTAINS

Systems Over Motivation

- Studio time goes on the calendar. Non-negotiable. Wednesday 2pm, Thursday 7pm, Saturday 10am. The muse shows up when you've built the habit of showing up.
- 1 focused hour daily for a year = 260 hours. That's a master's degree in studio time. Compare that to a 3-day workshop: 16 hours total, two weeks of inspiration, then back to zero.

*"Build a world, not just songs.
The right people will find you
when you have something real to find."*

READY FOR THE FULL SYSTEM?

The Rise Artist Course

riseartistacademy.com/the-artist-course

LEARN MORE